belonging to someone else. But unlike the US Constitution, the Ten Commandments failed to provide any amendment mechanism. There is no Eleventh Commandment that says, ‘You can amend commandments by a two-thirds majority vote.’

This crucial difference between the two texts is clear from their opening gambits. The US Constitution opens with ‘We the People’. By acknowledging its human origin, it invests humans with the power to amend it. The Ten Commandments open with ‘I am the Lord your God.’ By claiming divine origin, it precludes humans from changing it. As a result, the biblical text still endorses slavery even today.

All human political systems are based on fictions, but some admit it, and some do not. Being truthful about the origins of our social order makes it easier to make changes in it. If humans like us invented it, we can amend it. But such truthfulness comes at a price. Acknowledging the human origins of the social order makes it harder to persuade everyone to agree on it. If humans like us invented it, why should we accept it? As we shall see in chapter 5, until the late eighteenth century the lack of mass communication technology made it extremely difficult to conduct open debates between millions of people about the rules of the social order. To maintain order, Russian tsars, Muslim caliphs and Chinese sons of heaven therefore claimed that the fundamental rules of society came down from heaven and were not open to human amendment. In the early twenty-first century, many political systems still claim superhuman authority and oppose open debates that may result in unwelcome changes.

THE PERENNIAL DILEMMA

After we understand the key role of fiction in history, it is finally possible to present a more complete model of information networks, which goes beyond both the naive view of information and the populist critique of that view. Contrary to the naive view, information isn’t the raw material of truth, and human information networks aren’t geared only to discover the truth. But contrary to the populist view, information isn’t just a weapon, either. Rather, to survive and flourish, every human information network needs to do two things simultaneously: discover truth *and create order*. Accordingly, as history unfolded, human information networks have been developing two